

Chkdsk corrects disk errors only if you specify the “/f” command line option—it must be able to lock the drive to correct errors. Because repairs usually change a disk’s file allocation table and sometimes cause a loss of data, chkdsk sends a confirmation message similar to the following:

“10 lost allocation units found in 3 chains.  
Convert lost chains to files?”

If you press ‘Y’, Windows saves each lost chain in the root directory as a file with a name in the format File.chk. When chkdsk finishes, you can check these files to see if they contain any data you need. If you press ‘N’, Windows fixes the disk, but it does not save the contents of the lost allocation units.

- If you use “chkdsk /f” on a large disk (for example, 120 GB) or a disk with a very large number of files (for example, millions of files), chkdsk might take a long time (for example, over several days) to complete. The computer will not be available during this time because chkdsk does not relinquish control until it is finished.
- Use the “/r” command line option to find physical disk errors in the file system.
- The exit codes for Chkdsk are as follows.

0: No errors were found.

1: Errors were found and fixed.

2: Disk cleanup, such as garbage collection, was performed, or cleanup was not performed because “/f” was not specified.

3: Could not check the disk, errors could not be fixed, or errors were not fixed because “/f” was not specified.